

16

Defense, Resilience, and Counterplay

Survive queenside breakthroughs and know when the attack must pause



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

Learn the unglamorous skills that make the King's Indian a reliable primary defense.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate Black's candidates, find White's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 091 | PAGE 4

Decode: Meeting the Bayonet pressure*Counterattack works only while the position survives.*

LESSON 092 | PAGE 8

Play: Meeting the Bayonet pressure*Counterattack works only while the position survives.*

LESSON 093 | PAGE 12

Decode: Neutralizing c5 with capture*Defense is a favorable transformation, not merely a blocked file.*

LESSON 094 | PAGE 16

Play: Neutralizing c5 with capture*Defense is a favorable transformation, not merely a blocked file.*

LESSON 095 | PAGE 20

Decode: Pausing the pawn storm*Identity never outranks necessity.*

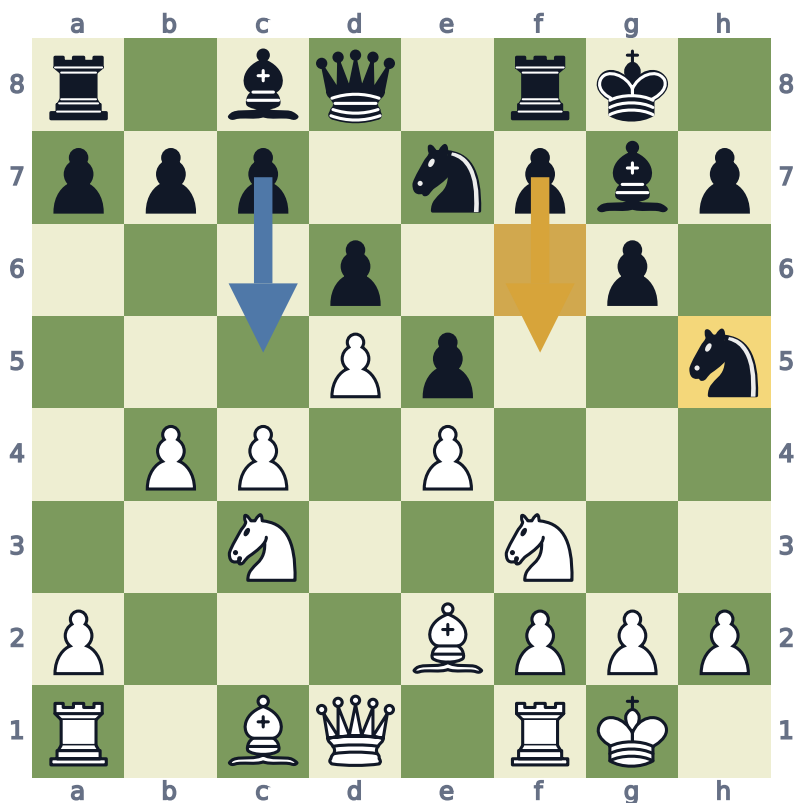
LESSON 096 | PAGE 24

Play: Pausing the pawn storm*Identity never outranks necessity.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

Learn the unglamorous skills that make the King's Indian a reliable primary defense.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Meeting the Bayonet pressure



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black combines kingside activity with a timely central challenge so White cannot expand without calculation.

DECISION RULE

If the kingside attack is not forcing, spend a tempo reducing White's strongest break.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Use ...c6 to question d5 and maintain enough queenside defense to keep the attack credible.

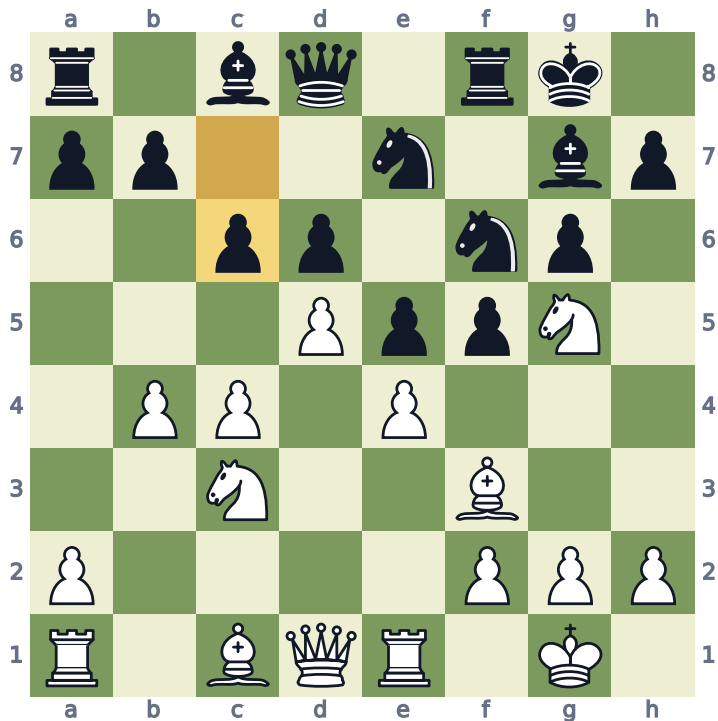
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White wants c5, a4, and b5 while exploiting the h5-knight.

MEMORY RULE | Counterattack works only while the position survives.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black combines kingside activity with a timely central challenge so White cannot expand without calculation.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Use ...c6 to question d5 and maintain enough queenside defense to keep the attack credible.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White wants c5, a4, and b5 while exploiting the h5-knight.

FAILURE MODE

Refusing all defensive moves is not bravery; it is loss of control.

DECISION TEST

Ask: If the kingside attack is not forcing, spend a tempo reducing White's strongest break. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

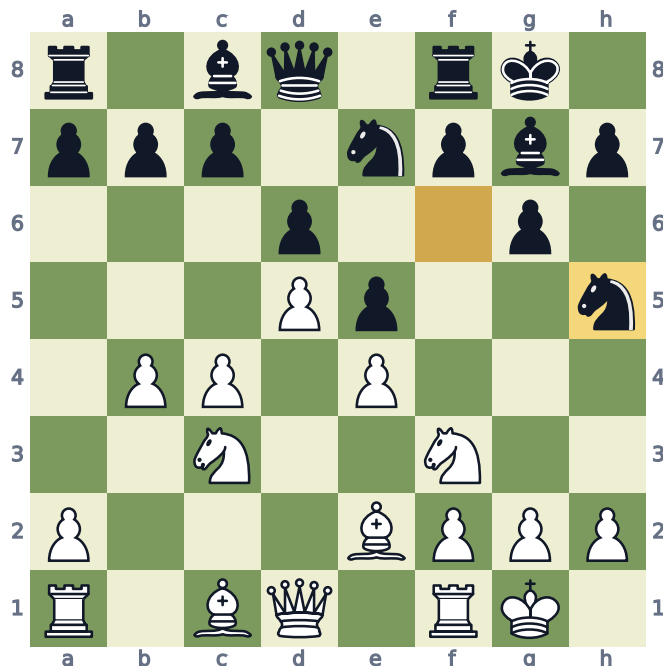
RULE | Counterattack works only while the position survives.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7 9. b4 Nh5 10. Re1 f5 11. Ng5 Nf6 12. Bf3 c6



- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight toward c6; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- d5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- Ne7: Black reroutes a knight toward e7; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- b4: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- Nh5: Black reroutes a knight toward h5; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black combines kingside activity with a timely central challenge so White cannot expand without calculation.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

If the kingside attack is not forcing, spend a tempo reducing White's strongest break. White's resistance is: White wants c5, a4, and b5 while exploiting the h5-knight. The line fails as a template when: Refusing all defensive moves is not bravery; it is loss of control.

STORE THIS | Counterattack works only while the position survives.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

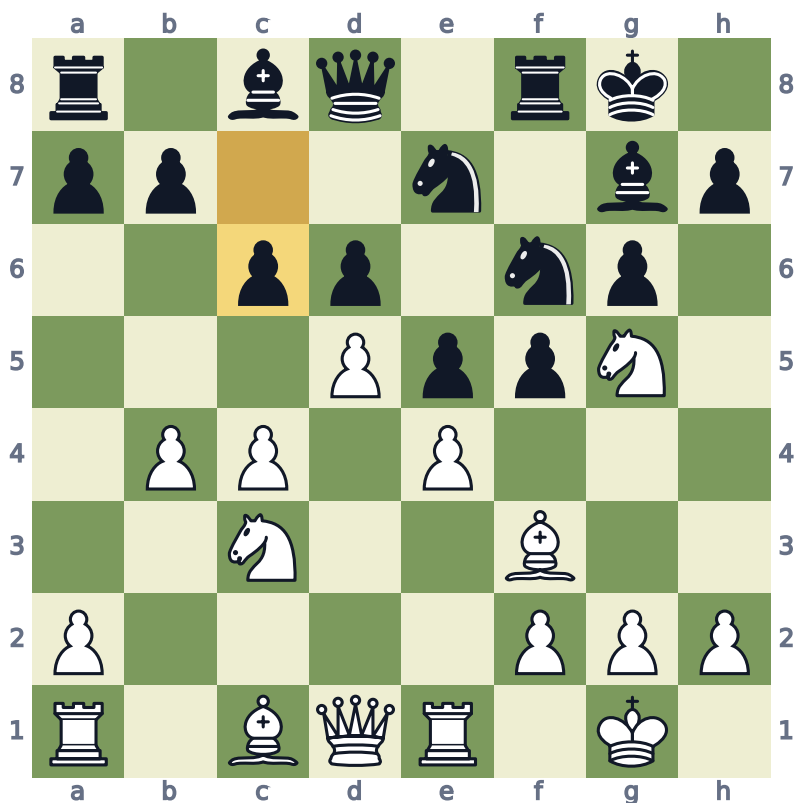
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7 9. b4 Nh5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Meeting the Bayonet pressure



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black combines kingside activity with a timely central challenge so White cannot expand without calculation.

DECISION RULE

If the kingside attack is not forcing, spend a tempo reducing White's strongest break.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

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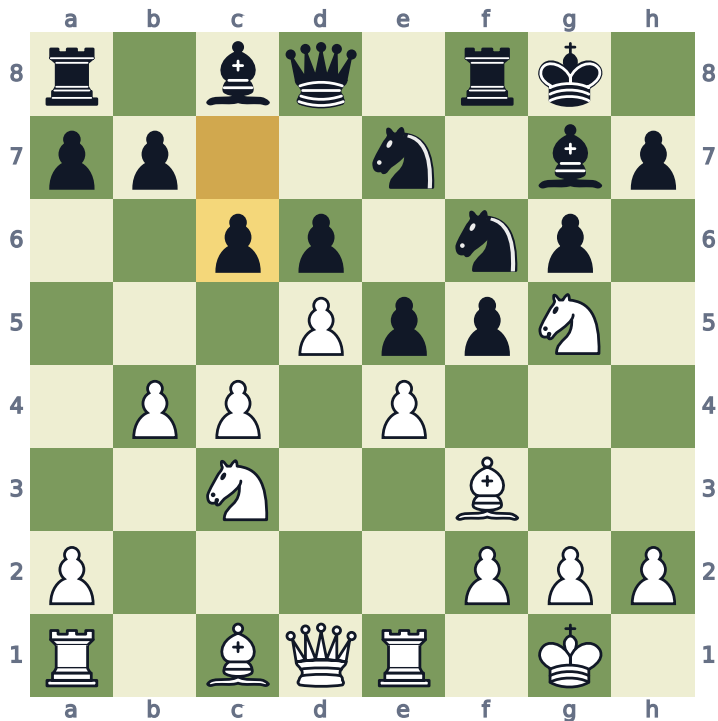
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MEMORY RULE | Counterattack works only while the position survives.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black combines kingside activity with a timely central challenge so White cannot expand without calculation.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Use ...c6 to question d5 and maintain enough queenside defense to keep the attack credible.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White wants c5, a4, and b5 while exploiting the h5-knight.

FAILURE MODE

Refusing all defensive moves is not bravery; it is loss of control.

DECISION TEST

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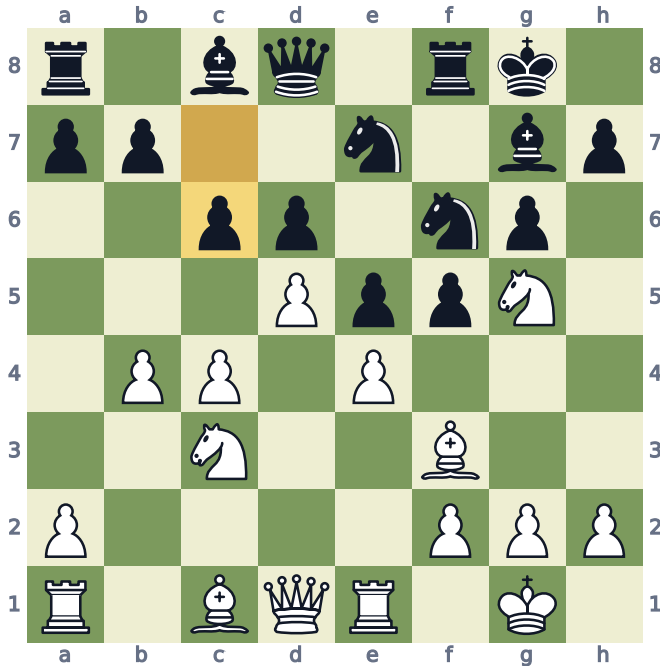
RULE | Counterattack works only while the position survives.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7 9. b4 Nh5 10. Re1 f5 11. Ng5 Nf6 12. Bf3 c6



- Re1: White places a rook on a line expected to open or uses it to support a central transformation.
- f5: Black begins the thematic kingside break, but its value depends on piece support and race timing.
- Ng5: White reroutes a knight toward g5; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight toward f6; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- Bf3: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- c6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black combines kingside activity with a timely central challenge so White cannot expand without calculation.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

If the kingside attack is not forcing, spend a tempo reducing White's strongest break. White's resistance is: White wants c5, a4, and b5 while exploiting the h5-knight. The line fails as a template when: Refusing all defensive moves is not bravery; it is loss of control.

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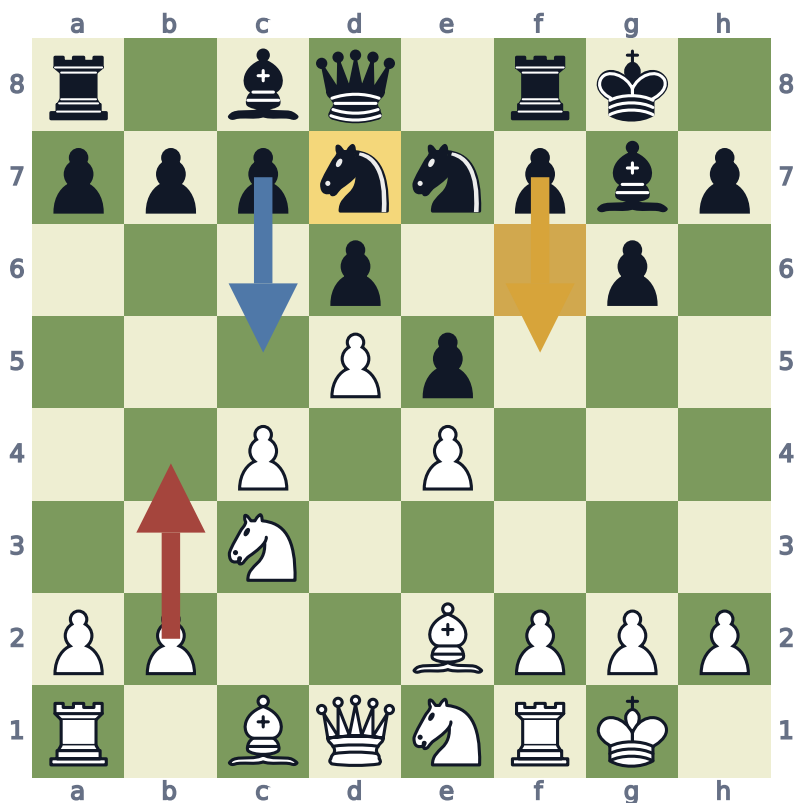
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 24 plies from memory, then replay: 10. Re1 f5 11. Ng5 Nf6 12. Bf3 c6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Neutralizing c5 with capture



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black can sometimes meet c5 by exchanging the advanced pawn and simplifying White's queenside initiative.

DECISION RULE

Choose capture only if the resulting trade reduces White's force without killing your own play.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Calculate the resulting piece activity and whether the d6 weakness disappears or becomes worse.

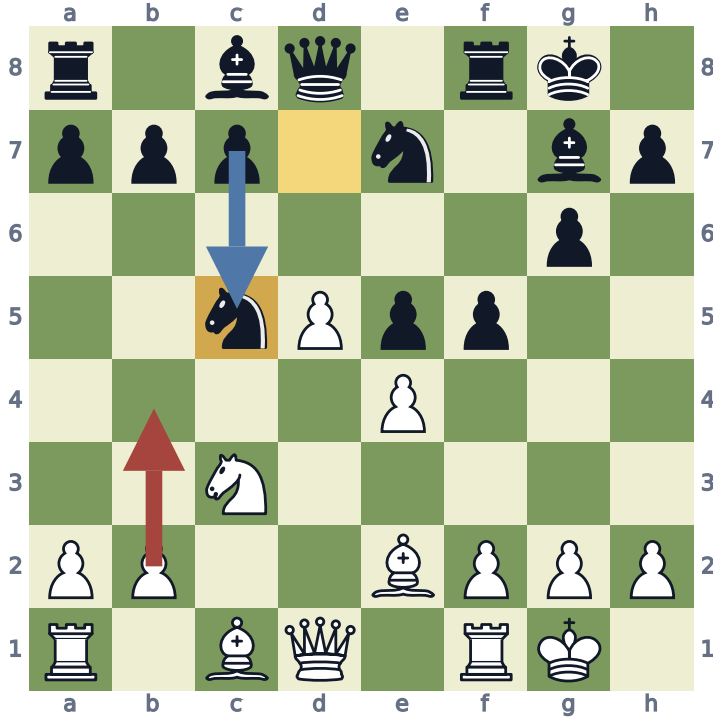
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses the recapture to activate a knight and open files.

MEMORY RULE | Defense is a favorable transformation, not merely a blocked file.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black can sometimes meet c5 by exchanging the advanced pawn and simplifying White's queenside initiative.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Calculate the resulting piece activity and whether the d6 weakness disappears or becomes worse.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White uses the recapture to activate a knight and open files.

FAILURE MODE

Automatic closure of the queenside can leave a permanent cramp.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Choose capture only if the resulting trade reduces White's force without killing your own play. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

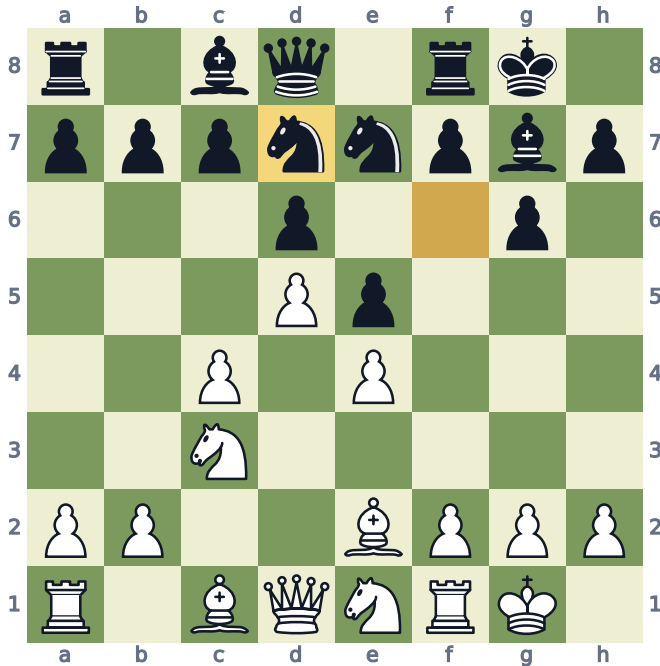
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7 9. Ne1 Nd7 10. Nd3 f5 11. c5 dxc5 12. Nxc5 Nxc5



- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight toward c6; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- d5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- Ne7: Black reroutes a knight toward e7; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- Ne1: White reroutes a knight toward e1; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- Nd7: Black reroutes a knight toward d7; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black can sometimes meet c5 by exchanging the advanced pawn and simplifying White's queenside initiative.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Choose capture only if the resulting trade reduces White's force without killing your own play. White's resistance is: White uses the recapture to activate a knight and open files. The line fails as a template when: Automatic closure of the queenside can leave a permanent cramp.

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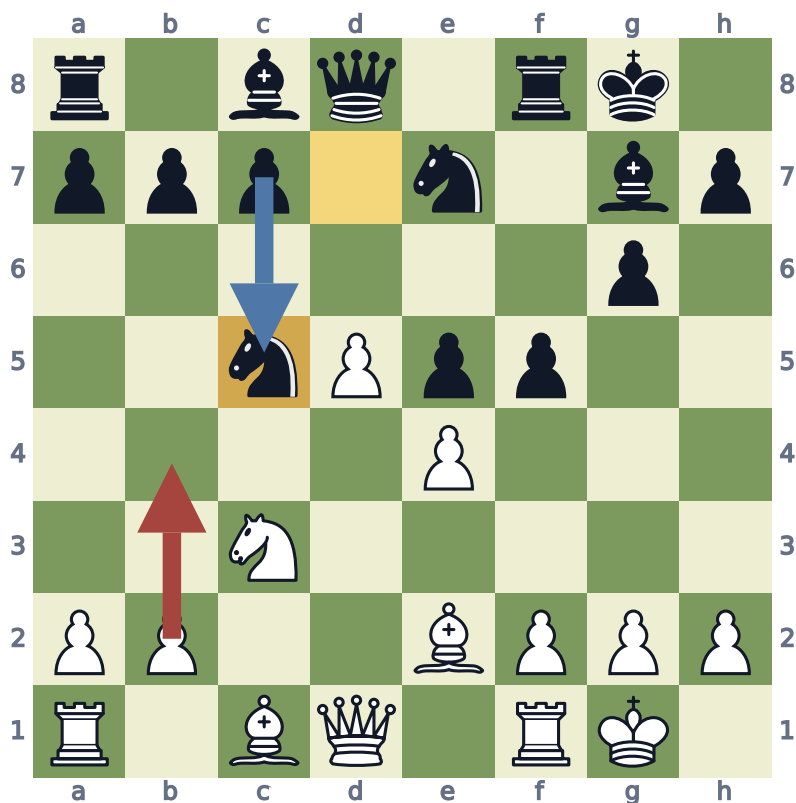
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7 9. Ne1 Nd7

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Choose capture only if the resulting trade reduces White's force without killing your own play.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

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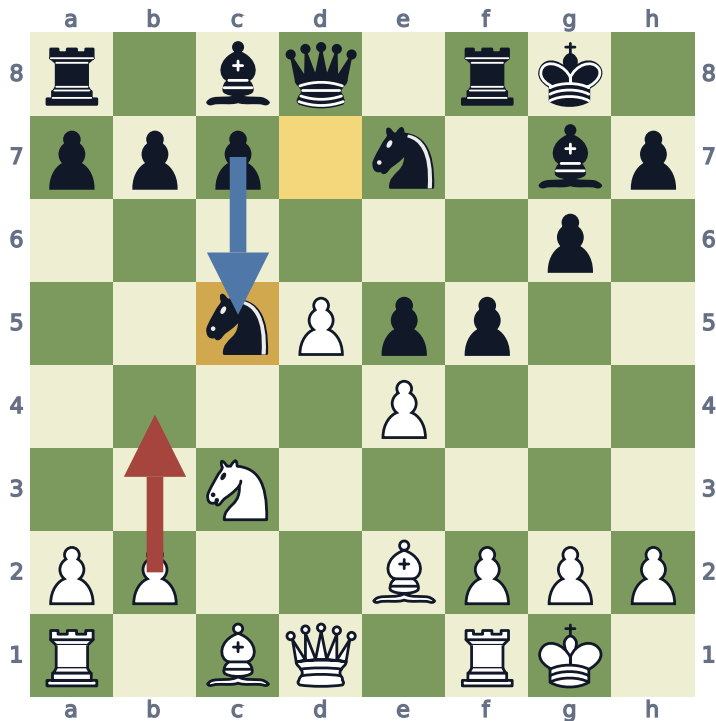
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White uses the recapture to activate a knight and open files.

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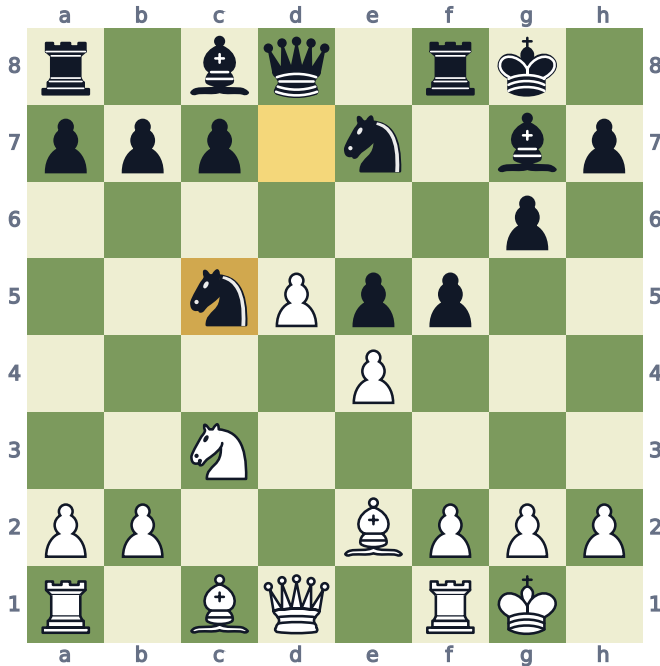
RULE | Defense is a favorable transformation, not merely a blocked file.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7 9. Ne1 Nd7 10. Nd3 f5 11. c5 dxc5 12. Nxc5 Nxc5



- Nd3: White reroutes a knight toward d3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- f5: Black begins the thematic kingside break, but its value depends on piece support and race timing.
- c5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- dxc5: Black attacks the center from the flank and invites a Benoni-like transformation.
- Nxc5: White reroutes a knight toward c5; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- Nxc5: Black reroutes a knight toward c5; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black can sometimes meet c5 by exchanging the advanced pawn and simplifying White's queenside initiative.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Choose capture only if the resulting trade reduces White's force without killing your own play. White's resistance is: White uses the recapture to activate a knight and open files. The line fails as a template when: Automatic closure of the queenside can leave a permanent cramp.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

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ANSWER KEY

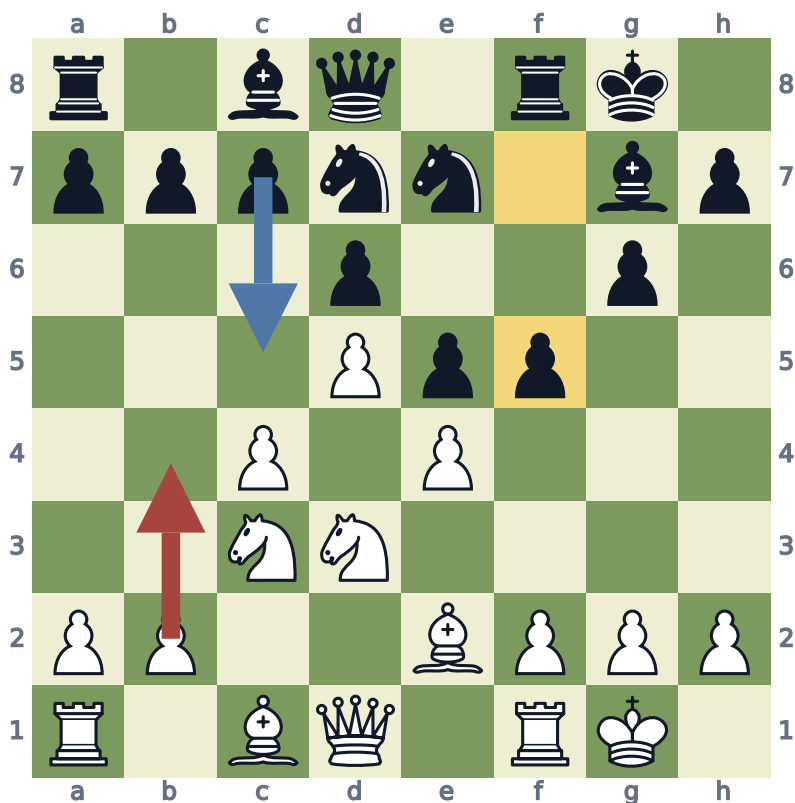
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 24 plies from memory, then replay: 10. Nd3 f5 11. c5 dxc5 12. Nxc5 Nxc5

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Pausing the pawn storm

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

White's c5 break may become more urgent than another kingside pawn push, requiring Black to improve a piece or defend a target.

DECISION RULE

Compare a forcing attack move with one consolidating move before deciding.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Preserve attacking potential while answering the concrete queenside threat.

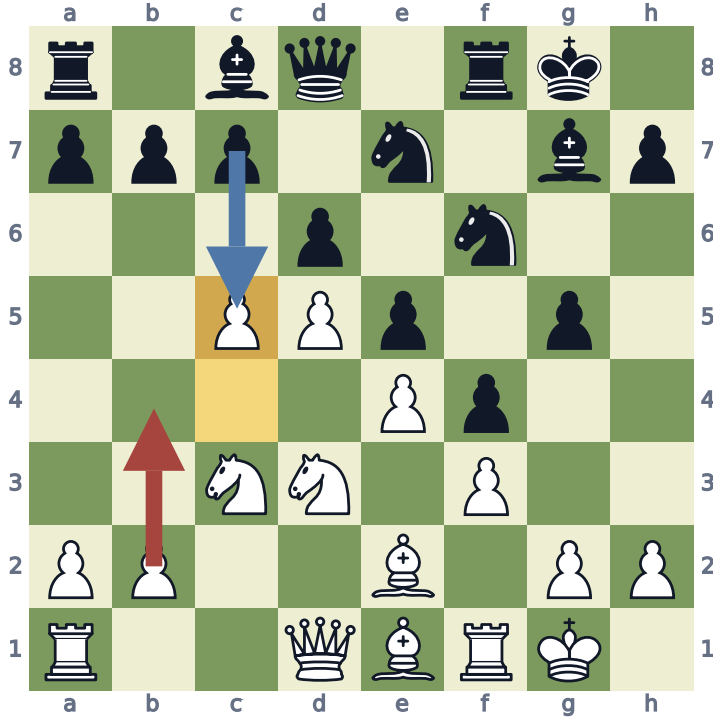
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White attacks d6 and c7 and may use Nb5.

MEMORY RULE | Identity never outranks necessity.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

White's c5 break may become more urgent than another kingside pawn push, requiring Black to improve a piece or defend a target.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Preserve attacking potential while answering the concrete queenside threat.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White attacks d6 and c7 and may use Nb5.

FAILURE MODE

Playing the "most King's Indian" move can be less accurate than playing the position.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Compare a forcing attack move with one consolidating move before deciding. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

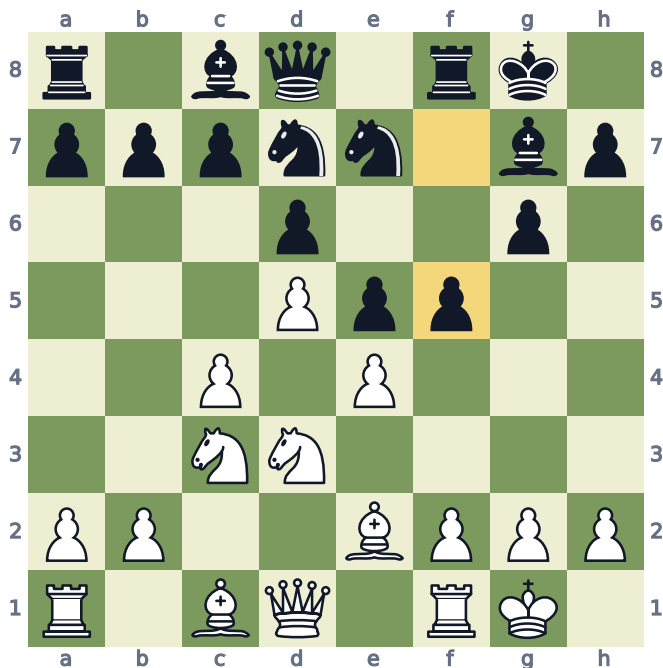
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7 9. Ne1 Nd7 10. Nd3 f5 11. Bd2 Nf6 12. f3 f4 13. Be1 g5 14. c5



- d5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- Ne7: Black reroutes a knight toward e7; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- Ne1: White reroutes a knight toward e1; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- Nd7: Black reroutes a knight toward d7; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- Nd3: White reroutes a knight toward d3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- f5: Black begins the thematic kingside break, but its value depends on piece support and race timing.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White's c5 break may become more urgent than another kingside pawn push, requiring Black to improve a piece or defend a target.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Compare a forcing attack move with one consolidating move before deciding. White's resistance is: White attacks d6 and c7 and may use Nb5. The line fails as a template when: Playing the "most King's Indian" move can be less accurate than playing the position.

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Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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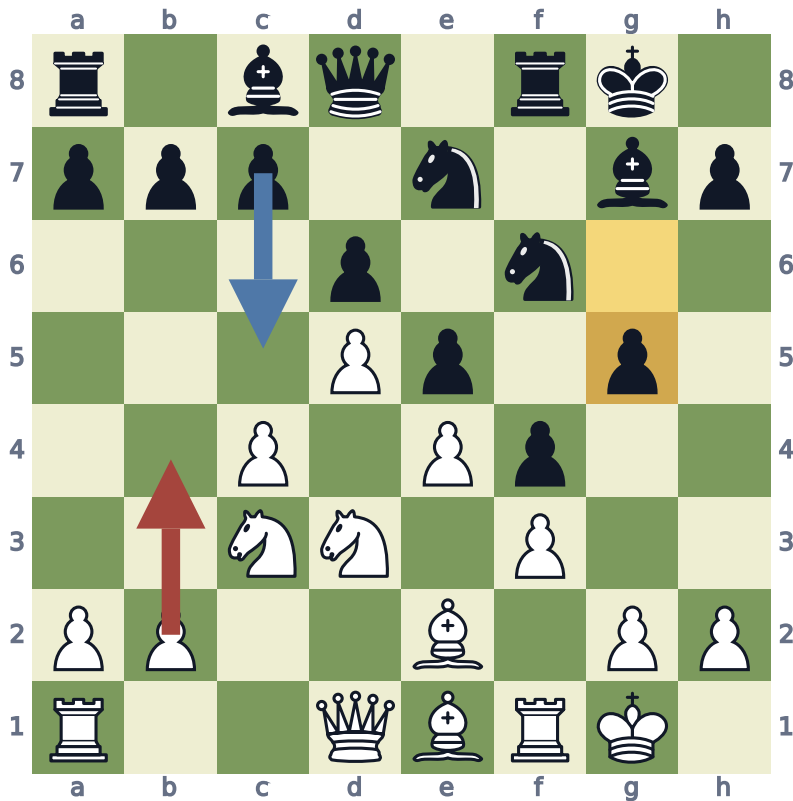
1. White's c5 break may become more urgent than another kingside pawn push, requiring Black to improve a piece or defend a target. 2. Preserve attacking potential while answering the concrete queenside threat. 3. White attacks d6 and c7 and may use Nb5. 4. Compare a forcing attack move with one consolidating move before deciding. 5. Playing the "most King's Indian" move can be less accurate than playing the position.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 20 plies from memory, then replay: 8. d5 Ne7 9. Ne1 Nd7 10. Nd3 f5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Pausing the pawn storm



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

White's c5 break may become more urgent than another kingside pawn push, requiring Black to improve a piece or defend a target.

DECISION RULE

Compare a forcing attack move with one consolidating move before deciding.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Preserve attacking potential while answering the concrete queenside threat.

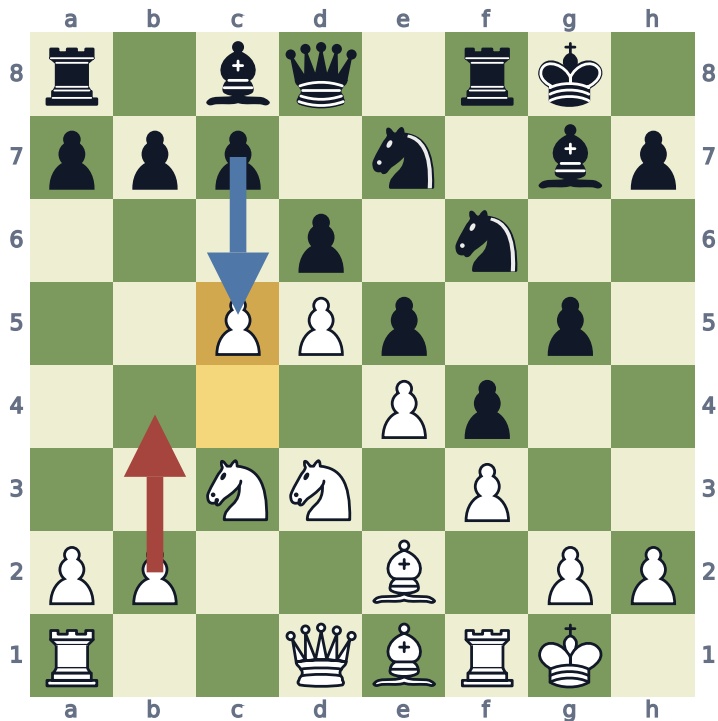
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

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CUE

White's c5 break may become more urgent than another kingside pawn push, requiring Black to improve a piece or defend a target.

BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

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FAILURE MODE

Playing the "most King's Indian" move can be less accurate than playing the position.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Compare a forcing attack move with one consolidating move before deciding. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

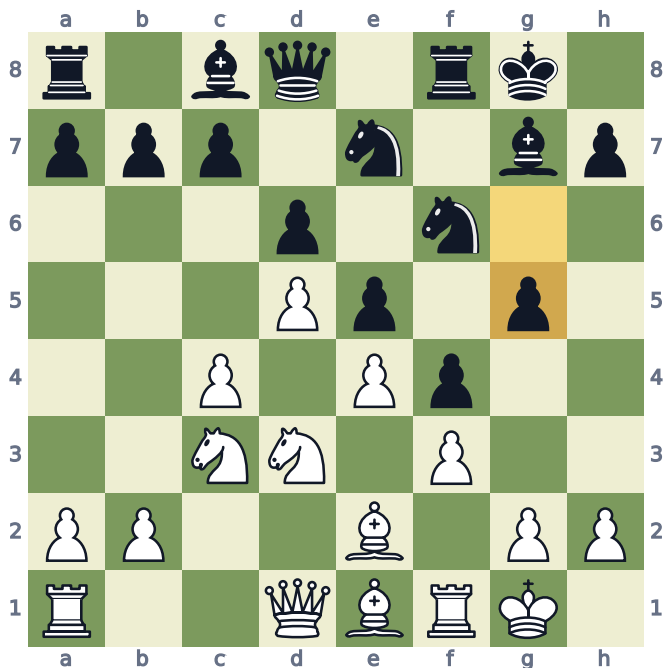
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7 9. Ne1 Nd7 10. Nd3 f5 11. Bd2 Nf6 12. f3 f4 13. Be1 g5 14. c5



- Bd2: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight toward f6; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- f3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- f4: Black gains or fixes kingside space and prepares line-opening contact for the pieces.
- Be1: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- g5: Black gains or fixes kingside space and prepares line-opening contact for the pieces.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White's c5 break may become more urgent than another kingside pawn push, requiring Black to improve a piece or defend a target.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

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ANSWER KEY

1. White's c5 break may become more urgent than another kingside pawn push, requiring Black to improve a piece or defend a target. 2. Preserve attacking potential while answering the concrete queenside threat. 3. White attacks d6 and c7 and may use Nb5. 4. Compare a forcing attack move with one consolidating move before deciding. 5. Playing the "most King's Indian" move can be less accurate than playing the position.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 26 plies from memory, then replay: 11. Bd2 Nf6 12. f3 f4 13. Be1 g5

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 091 Decode: Meeting the Bayonet pressure

Prompt: If the kingside attack is not forcing, spend a tempo reducing White's strongest break.

Recall: Counterattack works only while the position survives.

LESSON 092 Play: Meeting the Bayonet pressure

Prompt: If the kingside attack is not forcing, spend a tempo reducing White's strongest break.

Recall: Counterattack works only while the position survives.

LESSON 093 Decode: Neutralizing c5 with capture

Prompt: Choose capture only if the resulting trade reduces White's force without killing your own play.

Recall: Defense is a favorable transformation, not merely a blocked file.

LESSON 094 Play: Neutralizing c5 with capture

Prompt: Choose capture only if the resulting trade reduces White's force without killing your own play.

Recall: Defense is a favorable transformation, not merely a blocked file.

LESSON 095 Decode: Pausing the pawn storm

Prompt: Compare a forcing attack move with one consolidating move before deciding.

Recall: Identity never outranks necessity.

LESSON 096 Play: Pausing the pawn storm

Prompt: Compare a forcing attack move with one consolidating move before deciding.

Recall: Identity never outranks necessity.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's counterplay, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Meeting the Bayonet pressure

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7 9. b4 Nh5 10. Re1 f5 11. Ng5 Nf6 12. Bf3 c6

Decision: If the kingside attack is not forcing, spend a tempo reducing White's strongest break.

Memory: Counterattack works only while the position survives.

CARD 2

Neutralizing c5 with capture

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7 9. Ne1 Nd7 10. Nd3 f5 11. c5 dxc5 12. Nxc5 Nxc5

Decision: Choose capture only if the resulting trade reduces White's force without killing your own play.

Memory: Defense is a favorable transformation, not merely a blocked file.

CARD 3

Pausing the pawn storm

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7 9. Ne1 Nd7 10. Nd3 f5 11. Bd2 Nf6 12. f3 f4 13. Be1 g5 14. c5

Decision: Compare a forcing attack move with one consolidating move before deciding.

Memory: Identity never outranks necessity.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
091 Decode: Meeting the Bayonet pressure	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
092 Play: Meeting the Bayonet pressure	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
093 Decode: Neutralizing c5 with capture	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
094 Play: Neutralizing c5 with capture	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
095 Decode: Pausing the pawn storm	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
096 Play: Pausing the pawn storm	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name White's best counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.